

Journal of Multicultural Discourses

ISSN: 1744-7143 (Print) 1747-6615 (Online) Journal homepage: http://www.tandfonline.com/loi/rmmd20

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To cite this article: Doreen D. Wu, Yu Huang & Ming Liu (2015) Competing and hybridized discourses in Chinese news reporting: case studies of three key newspapers in Southern China, Journal of Multicultural Discourses, 10:1, 67-84, DOI: 10.1080/17447143.2014.946037

To link to this article: http://dx.doi.org/10.1080/17447143.2014.946037

Published online: 27 Aug 2014.

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Journal of Multicultural Discourses, 2015
Vol. 10, No. 1, 67–84, http://dx.doi.org/10.1080/17447143.2014.946037

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Competing and hybridized discourses in Chinese news reporting: case studies of three key newspapers in Southern China

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(*Received 29 July 2013; accepted 12 July 2014*)

Comparative discourse studies have tended to emphasize uncovering the dichotomous systems or the differential ideological patterning between the East and the West. The present study attempts a turn in moving beyond the dichotomous perspective to examine the complexities and the internal variations within the Chinese culture and discourse. It explores the diverse discourse systems operating in the media practice of contemporary China and emphasizes that a discourse system is dynamic and constantly undergoing changes, competing with other discourse system(s) and incorporating elements from the other discourse system(s). The notion of stance by Du Bois is utilized to study the different possible stances the three key newspapers in Southern China (i.e. *Shenzhen Special Zone Daily*, *Guangzhou Daily*, and *Southern Metropolis Daily*) have adopted in reporting the case of the Sanlu milk scandal, manifesting the competing forces and the changing Chinese media in a globalizing context, with differential extent of hybridization between at least two discourses: the politically driven and the professionally driven discourses.

Keywords: comparative discourse studies; hybridity; stance-taking; Chinese news

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Introduction

Social changes in China and the Sanlu milk scandal

This research addresses a key issue that has drawn increasing attention from scholars of sociology and political science (e.g. Chan and Qiu 2001; Lee 2003; Ma 2012) but remains relatively unexplored in language and communication studies, i.e., the competing forces in China's media practice and the hybridized discursive space in current Chinese media. Scholars such as Lee (2003, 1) suggest that China's media has been caught in the crosscurrents of nationalism and globalism, whereas others (e.g. Ma 2012; Tong 2009) have further noted that the current Chinese media cannot be purely attributed to an authoritarian system but represent a dissonant mixture of a number of different discourse systems such as neoconservatism, liberalism, old and new leftism, etc. The present study, therefore, attempts to utilize the concept of stance-taking by Du Bois (2007) to further manifest the changing relations between language, power, and ideology in contemporary Chinese media practice, via a case study of the reporting of the Sanlu milk scandal.

Sanlu milk powder scandal is a food safety incident in China, which broke on 16 July 2008 after 16 infants in Gansu province, who had been fed on the milk powder produced by Sanlu Group, were diagnosed with kidney problems. It was found that the milk and

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infant formula produced by Sanlu Group, a state-owned diary product group based in Shijiazhuang in Hebei province, was adulterated with melamine, a chemical product which was intentionally added to the milk to increase the nitrogen element content in order to pass the measure from the institutional authority, but the product can cause kidney problems of all sorts to babies.

Sanlu was one of the oldest and most popular brands of infant formula in China, and used to be the marker leader in the budget segment, with a larger market share in terms of the infant formula. It was later revealed by *Xinhua News Agency* that Sanlu Group had received its first complaint about its baby milk as early as in December 2007, but it was either ignored or covered up by Sanlu Group and local officials in China. As further investigation moved on, the same chemical product, melamine, was found to exist, though to a lesser degree, in a number of other brands in China including Mengiu and Yili, i.e., it seemed that the adding of melamine had become a 'latent rule' in the Chinese milk industry (Elegant 2008).

By November 2008, China reported an estimated 300,000 victims of the Chinese milk scandal, with six infants dying from kidney damage, and an estimated 54,000 babies being hospitalized (Branigan 2008). This whole incident has stirred a wide panic in the whole country and raised serious concerns both locally and globally about food safety and political corruption in China. The World Health Organization regarded this as one of the largest safety events in recent years. In spite of Beijing's efforts to execute criminal charges and prosecutions against the evil manufacturers and the corrupted officials related to this incident and to install more measures for milk and food safety in China, the effects of this incident are much more pernicious and disgraceful than anticipated. Quite a few countries have stopped all imports of Chinese diary products. Furthermore, up until today, amid confidence crisis, millions of Chinese parents are trying to purchase foreign milk powder from outside China while retailers of foreign milk powder are exercising certain restrictions due to pressure and need from their country residents (Hatton 2013; Xinhua 2013).

The theoretical background

Beyond the dichotomy of discourse systems

Comparative discourse studies in the past decades have tended to emphasize uncovering the dichotomous systems or the differential ideological patterning between the East and the West. In their reputable work of proposing a discourse approach to intercultural communication, Scollon and Scollon (1995/2001) postulate the notion of 'discourse system' which refers to a self-contained system of communication operating within a speech community with its shared forms of discourse being governed by ideology and achieved by socialization. Scollon and Scollon (1995/2001) further exemplify the notion by manifesting a dominant discourse system which prevails in the West as the Utilitarian Discourse System and a dominant one in the East as the Confucianist Discourse System. Over the past decades, aligned with the work by Scollon and Scollon (1995/2001), scholars in comparative discourse studies have tended to take a dichotomous approach, focusing on the differential ideological patterning or distinctive forms of discourse between the East and the West: for example, Fang (2001) compares the differential discourse strategies by *People's Daily* in Beijing versus *Central Daily News* in Taiwan in reporting same events; Murata (2007) discusses the pro- and anti-whaling discourses by the British versus the Japanese; Li (2009) manifests the different intertextual resources being realized in the *New York Times*' versus *China Daily*'s reports in constructing

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specific understandings of national identities and positions, while Bonyadi (2010) identifies the different discourse conventions in the English versus the Persian editorials.

While the present research utilizes the notion of 'discourse system' proposed by Scollon and Scollon (1995/2001), it attempts a turn in moving beyond the dichotomous perspective to examine the complexities and the internal variations within a culture or nation, i.e., it pays special attention to the diverse and competing discourse systems in contemporary Chinese media practice. The perspective adopted here echoes and aligns closely with what Shi-xu (2009a, 2009b) proposes as the dialectic approach to the understanding of the universe and with what Chen (2009) proposes as the beyond the dichotomy of communication studies. Specifically, three tenets are entailed: (1) the universe is a unity of interdependent, interpenetrating, and interchanging parts; (2) there is a dialectical and dialogical relationship between the Eastern/Chinese and the Western cultures which often leads to a state of multicontextual existence; (3) the paradigmatic assumptions of the different cultures represent a continuum in which each culture orients to a different point in it.

The present study aims to manifest a state of multicontextual existence in contemporary Chinese media systems and practice. It also emphasizes that while the identification of different discourse systems requires the understanding of each discourse system as an independent and isolated entity, each discourse system is not always stable but dynamic. A discourse system may undergo constant changes, competing with and influencing the other system(s). Besides, the identification of each discourse system in terms of shared language forms often tends to ignore the complexities of each discourse system, as the discourse system may vary not so much in the choice of language forms or jargons, but in the extent particular social relationships and ideologies are instantiated in the discourse. Based on the notion and thesis here, the following will focus on two diverse but interpenetrating discourse systems within contemporary China: the politically driven discourse and the professionally driven discourse systems.

Diverse discourses in contemporary China

With the reforms and transformation from the state-planned economy to a market economy over the past decades, significant changes have been taken place in China's journalistic systems and practice, which have drawn continuous attention from the media scholars (e.g. Chan 1993; Guo and Huang 2002; He 2000; Huang and Lee 2002; Wu and Hui 1997; Wu and Ng 2011). Based on a review of the work that has been done in this area, we can identify and summarize at least two competing journalistic systems coexisting in contemporary China as: politically driven and professionally driven. Each of the discourse systems can be characterized by their own ideologies, prototypical social relations, and face systems, which can be represented via a list of features such as the prescribed aims and functions of the journalistic practice, the values held among the journalists and their particular ways of alignment, and their reporting style, etc. (see Table 1).

The politically driven journalism in China has its origin and borrowing from the Russian communism in which Lenin's three roles of the press – propagandist, agitator, and organizer – are the official guidelines for the Chinese media (see also De Burgh 2003). The politically driven discourse aims to sustain power and dominance, values most to be politically correct, and aligns primarily with the government or the party. In terms of reporting style, it tends to be formal and harmony-driven (see also Wu and Hui 1997).

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Table 1. Typical features of discourse systems in China.

Types	Politically driven	Professionally driven
Aims	To sustain dominance	To pursue truth
Functions	Propaganda	Investigation
Values	To be politically correct	To be objective and fair
Alignment	With the government	With the public
Style	Formal, harmonious	Critical, conflictual

However, with extensive market-oriented reform in China and the promotion of media commercialization, the professionally driven discourse has gradually taken shape in China, as aiming to be responsive to the market needs entails engaging or catering to the interests of the public. The forms of investigative reports and provocative commentary with its primary aim to penetrate the truth behind each incident have thus become popular in China (Pan and Lu 2003). Such professionally driven discourse places high values on objectivity and fairness in news reporting, on seeking truth and serving the civil society. It resembles the ideology and practice of a socially responsible press in the West (see McQuail 1994) and is characterized by balanced reporting and critical style.

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Stance-taking

While some previous studies used to resort to the identification of some typical language forms for the distinction of different discourse systems (e.g. Fang 2001; Murata 2007; Scollon and Scollon 1995/2001), the present study attempts to examine the different ways of stance-taking that distinguish these discourse systems, especially in the representations of the same event in the same sociocultural context. In this study, the holistic concept of stance proposed by Du Bois (2007) is adapted, which defines stance as:

> a public act by a social actor, achieved dialogically through overt communicative means (language, gesture, and other symbolic forms), through which social actors simultaneously evaluate objects, position subjects (themselves and others), and align with other subjects, with respect to any salient dimension of value in the sociocultural field. (Du Bois 2007, 163)

The advantage of this concept is that it emphasizes stance as a public act, which means that it is something we do rather than an interior property of psyche. This can be achieved through our communicative means, be it language, gesture, and other symbolic forms. Furthermore, Du Bois (2007) specifies three fundamental and interrelated aspects of stance: evaluation, positioning, and alignment. In other words, examining the stance of a news report involves looking at how it simultaneously evaluates the subjects (attitude), how it positions itself (positioning), and how it seeks alignment/disalingment with relevant parties (e.g. the readers, its superiors) (alignment/disalignment).

This approach toward stance no longer confines itself to the identification of the particular forms which express evaluative meanings or the classification of semantic meanings. It presupposes the idea that every communicative act communicates stance, even the most neutral one. Besides, stance is also cumulative, dialogic, and ideological. It is cumulative, because to understand the stance of a newspaper toward a particular event requires the examination of its whole reports during a period of time. Although it is possible to examine stance meanings in a particular news text, the analysis tends to be

biased and inaccurate, because that news text may not be able to represent the real stance of a newspaper. In order to show a balanced and objective image, a newspaper may represent both the positive voice and the negative voice through the choice of a number of reports. The identification of the stance thus should be based on the understanding of these reports on the whole. Stance is also dialogic, because 'stance is always taken in alignment with or in opposition to other possible stances' (Coupland and Coupland 2009, 228). So the identification of the stance of a newspaper necessitates a comparative study between it and other newspapers. Stance is also ideologically significant, because it often obscures itself and is taken for granted. The identification of stance can unreal the ideology behind it (Thompson and Hunston 2000). This concept of stance is particularly relevant to the examination of the two competing media systems in China, because their differences can be instantiated in the varied stances they take in their reports on a particular event.

The analysis of stance for this study will be based on the approach to evaluation and the Appraisal Theory proposed by Jim Martin and his colleagues (see Martin 2000; Martin and White 2005). The proposal that the analysis of evaluative meanings should not be reduced to the mere identification of evaluative forms is adopted in this study as Hunston (2007) argues that the interpretation of stance requires a deep understanding of the discourse as a whole rather than the mere examination of the co-text of a lexical item. Martin (2000) also suggests that although evaluative meanings can be explicitly expressed in certain linguistic forms, it can also be evoked:

> inscribed appraisal is explicitly expressed in the text (*a **bright** kid*, *a **vicious** kid*), whereas with evoked appraisal an evaluative response is projected by reference to events or states which are conventionally prized (*a kid who reads a lot*) or frowned on (a kid who tears the wings off butterflies; Martin 2000, 142).

In short, this research will not focus on the forms of evaluation, but the types of evaluative meanings expressed either explicitly or implicitly, according to the 'positive–negative' parameter. It is hoped that such analysis of evaluation in the news reports will reveal not only the particular stance taken by a newspaper toward the event of Sanlu milk scandal and its agents and patients, but also the particular ways of stance-taking that characterize the newspaper representing a particular discourse system.

Data and methods of analysis

This research selects three typical newspapers from the Guangdong province in South China for a comparative study, i.e., *Shenzhen Special Zone Daily* (hereafter SZD), *Guangzhou Daily* (hereafter GZD), and *Southern Metropolis Daily* (hereafter SMD). These three newspapers are chosen because they are all located in Southern China, which is known for its status as the forefront of China's opening and reform. Guangdong is one of the three bases of China's media industry and takes the leading role in China's media reform.

Furthermore, these three newspapers are selected because they represent varied ideology and positioning in the newspaper production in contemporary China. SZD is an official newspaper of the Shenzhen Municipal Party Committee. Launched on 24 May 1982, it is the first and also the most authoritative daily paper in China's special economic zone – Shenzhen. It ranks top three in China in terms of comprehensive economic strength, and boasts a daily circulation of 600,000 copies. It is known as a typical party

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press and claimed as the only local newspaper subscribed by the State Council. GZD is the official newspaper of the Guangzhou Municipal Party Committee published by the *Guangzhou Daily* Newspaper Group. Established on 1 December 1952, it is one of the largest official newspapers in China, with a daily circulation of 1.85 million copies. Located in Southern China, it is always at the forefront of China's press reform and also China's most successfully marketized newspaper, so it has long been the number one daily newspaper in Southern China. Although it is still a party newspaper like SZD, it is known for its originality and professionalism. Well adapted to the market, it achieves 2.2 billion advertising avenue a year, thus ranking among the most profitable newspapers in China. SMD is known as the most professional and 'rebellious' newspaper in China. As a product of China's opening and reform, it was launched on 30 March 1995 by Southern Media Group, thus the youngest of these three newspapers. With its slogan 'To be the best newspaper in China,' it is known for its investigative journalism and provocative commentary. Despite its young age, it has developed into one of the most successful newspapers in China, boasting a daily circulation of 1.4 millions and achieving 1.8 billion yuan advertising avenue a year.

The present analysis focuses primarily on the reports related to Sanlu milk scandal from 12 September 2008 to 30 September 2008.[1] September 12 is the day when the incident was first disclosed in the media. Such an initial short period is chosen, because the coverage of a negative story in this period tends to show greater variety as the government has not got the time to intervene in the reporting. The keyword 'Sanlu milk' was utilized to search all the concerned news texts from each newspaper in the electronic newspaper database *wisenews*, and information about these news texts is summarized in Table 2.

We can observe that the three newspapers show great differences in the number of news texts, which in turn indicates the different weight given to the incident by each newspaper. It shows that the incident receives the least attention from SZD but the greatest attention from SMD. This indicates that SMD is the most responsive to this event and to the interests of the public since the milk scandal concerns closely the life of the people. Besides, the number of commentaries in each newspaper also reveals each newspaper's stance toward the event, since commentaries often tend to be critical and a typical sign of professionalism in Chinese newspapers. We can observe that no commentary can be found in SZD, while 3 commentaries can be found in GZD, and 18 in SMD.

The following section adopts a stance-taking perspective, analyzing the news discourse further from two aspects: voices and evaluations. The former examines who are given voices in these news texts, which can indicate the particular ways of alignment or disalignment by each newspaper with particular groups of people. The latter is concerned with the communication of attitudes and evaluative meanings by each newspaper toward the four important agents in the Sanlu milk scandal, including the

Table 2. Information about news reports in three newspapers.

Newspapers	News	Comment	Life and entertainment	Total
SZD	27	0	0	27
GZD	69	3	5	77
SMD	147	18	6	171

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government, the Sanlu Group, the baby victims, and the worried parents. It is believed that a combined voice and evaluation analysis can reveal the particular ways of stance-taking (i.e. evaluation, positioning, and alignment/disalignment) in each newspaper, representing the particular professional persona of each newspaper.

Findings

Voices

One of the crucial features of news reporting is the frequent reference to the speeches of others (e.g. van Dijk 1988). Bell (1991, 53) further points out that 'news is what people say more than what people do.' The study of represented discourses or news sources thus involves a series of important questions that cut to the heart of contemporary journalism. One of the questions is who are given voices in news reports, because it can indicate the particular ways of alignment or disalignment of each newspaper.

Based on a detailed manual analysis, four dominant categories of voices emerge in these news reports: 'officials and government,' 'experts,' 'salesman and companies,' and 'the public and victims.' The category of 'officials' refers to those officials from different departments of the government at different levels in China, e.g. 甘肃省卫生厅 (Gansu Provincial Department of Public Health), 卫生部 (Ministry of Health), 外交部发言人 (spokesperson for China Foreign Ministry), and 东莞市卫生局有关负责人 (person in charge of Dongguan Health Bureau). They are people and departments who represent the voice of the government(s) and are responsible for handling the problems caused by the incident. In this incident, 'experts' mainly involve people with professional skills and knowledge, especially medical knowledge, such as 泌尿外科专家孙宁 (Sun Ning, an expert of urology), 联合调查组专家 (experts of the joint investigation team), and 姓赵的护士 (a nurse surnamed Zhao). Their voices stand out in these news reports, because they can provide information about the development of the incident, report the conditions of those baby victims, and/or offer professional advice for the public. The category of 'salesman and companies' is another important category in these news reports, because it includes not only the voices of Sanlu Company, the main culprit of the scandal, but also the voices of those people who are responsible for the sales of the milk products, e.g. 一些超市的工作人员 (workers in some supermarkets), 销售人员 (salesmen), and 市场部经理 (manager of the marketing department). The presence of these voices can provide information about the sales of adulterated milk products in the market and about what remedial measures are being taken by the government or the relevant corporations. The last category, 'the public and victims,' represents people who are directly affected by the incident. Typical examples are 广州 '妈妈' ('Mums' in Guangzhou), 网友 '小摩女' (Netizen 'Xiaomuonv'), 在黄沙工作的许先生 (Mr Xu working in Huang Sha), etc. Detailed information about the distribution of the four categories of voices is summarized in Table 3.

Table 3 shows that each newspaper uses a large quantity of represented voices (111 in SZD, 271 in GZD, and 634 in SMD), but the distribution of the four categories in each newspaper has demonstrated great variety. In order to better reveal how much weight each category of voices is given, their percentages in the total amount of voices represented in each newspaper are compared and further illustrated in Figure 1.

As can be seen from the above figures, the category of 'officials' always accounts for the largest share of voices in all the three newspapers, even though the figure declines from 71% in SZD to 49% in GZD, and to only 35% in SMD. This reveals that all the three newspapers attach great importance to all official voices, which is in congruent with

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Table 3. Information about the different categories of agents.

	SZD		GZD		SMD	
Categories	Frequency	%	Frequency	%	Frequency	%
Officials	79	71	133	49	224	35
Experts	20	18	66	24	133	21
Salesman and companies	6	5	30	11	122	19
The public and victims	6	5	42	15	155	24
Total	111	100	271	100	634	100

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China's media role as a party organ. Furthermore, the percentage of 'expert' voices is relatively stable in all the three newspapers. This might be due to the special role of expert voices in contemporary China, which can both 'lend legitimacy to the state and its policy' and 'add credibility, authority, and even a touch of independence' to news reports (Chan and Qiu 2001).

Nonetheless, the three newspapers reveal greater variety in the weight they give to the other two categories of voices. In SZD, the category of 'salesman and companies' and the category of 'the public and victims' take only 5%, respectively. But the percentage of the category 'salesman and companies' rises to 11% in GZD and to 19% in SMD. A similar trend can also be found in the category of 'the public and victims,' which rises to 14% in GZD and to 24% in SMD. This suggests that GZD and SMD, though still toeing the party line, align more closely with the interests of the public than SZD does.

Viewed on the whole, we can see SZD is most slanted in the representation of the four categories of voices, while a relatively balanced representation of the four categories of voices can be identified in SMD. Intermediate between them is the GZD. This clearly manifests the primary politically driven nature of SZD, which serves as a typical party organ in the representation of such an incident involving great challenges to the image of the government. The increasing weight given to the voices of the public in GZD and SMD can be attributed to their heightened awareness of the market, of the interests of the public, and their pursuit of professionalism. This is especially evident in SMD, where the voices of 'the public and victim' ranks the second among all the four categories of voices reported. The relatively balanced treatment of the different categories of voices by SMD can also be viewed as sign of their pursuit of professionalism, which characterizes Western liberal journalism.

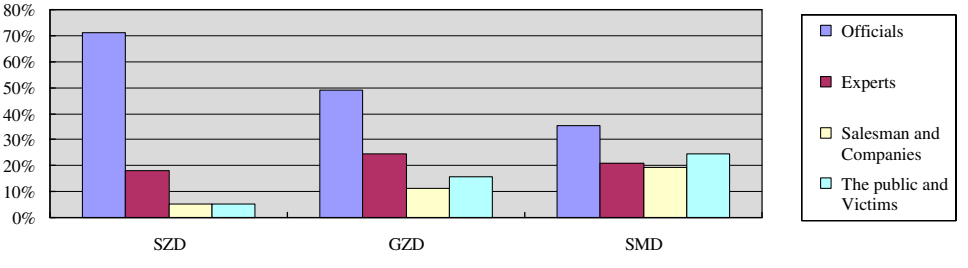


Figure 1. Percentages of four categories of voices in three newspapers.
Note: SZD, *Shenzhen Special Zone Daily*; GZD, *Guangzhou Daily*; SMD, *Southern Metropolis Daily*.

However, the sole examination of the distribution of the different categories of voices is suggestive but not sufficient for manifesting the varied stances by the newspapers; and the following section will further examine how the different parties are evaluated in these newspapers.

Evaluations

This part examines the representations and evaluations of the four important groups of agents by the three newspapers: the government, the Sanlu Group, the baby victim, and the worried parents. Relevant to the present analysis include the notions of positive versus negative evaluation, of inscribed and evoked appraisal, and of affect, judgment, and appreciation,[2] as stipulated in the Appraisal Theory by Martin and his colleagues (Martin and White 2005; White 2003). The analysis focuses on both news titles and the body texts.

The government

As shown above, the largest share of voices has been given to the government, which suggests that the government has been taken as an important agent by the three newspapers. This important role given to the government can also be reflected in the news headlines as the speeches and action of the government officials are often represented prominently in the news headlines.

News headlines not only signal the main topic of the news but also suggest a 'preferred overall meaning of the text' (van Dijk 1988, 40). Furthermore, Bell (1991, 186) points out that 'the headline is a newspaper's opportunity to stamp its individuality on what is otherwise a mass-produced product' and that news headlines tend to begin with main news actors. While Van Dijk (1988, 227) has observed that authorities tend to dominate the first position in news headlines with active verbs, we observe in the present study that the percentages of headlines with the government as its actor in SZD, GZD, and SMD are 70% (19 out of 27), 36% (28 out of 77), and 15% (26 out of 171), respectively.

Furthermore, the three newspapers show different degrees of alignment or disalignment with the government, as revealed in their particular ways of representing these agents from the government. SZD always gives a positive evaluation of the government actors' behavior with expressions such as 緊急 (*urgently*), 爭分奪秒 (*racing against the time*), and 全面 (*thoroughly*). Examples are as follows:

各地爭分奪秒救治腎結石患兒. (SZD, 16 September 2008)
Racing against time to treat the 'kidney-stone' babies **everywhere**

廣東緊急清查三鹿奶粉. (SZD, 13 September 2008)
Guangdong province has given a **thorough** check of Sanlu milk powder.

However, GZD gives a quite neutral representation of the actions of the government:

省政府召開會議部署三鹿奶粉事件處置工作. (GZD, 18 September 2008)
Provincial government held a meeting for handling the incident of Sanlu milk powder

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溫家寶昨日在北京看望‘奶粉事件’患病兒童並考察奶製品市場. (GZD, 22 September 2008)

Wen Jiabao went to see those babies suffering from the ‘milk scandal’ and investigated the market of milk product yesterday.

SMD not only gives a small share of headlines to the representations of the government but also presents a mildly negative evaluation of the government in handling the incident. An evoked appraisal by SMD that the government was negligent of their duties when handling the complaints against Sanlu Group can be observed in the following report:

質檢網站A月即有投訴　回複多為‘請提供　詳細信息’A‘向衛生部反映’和‘正在調查’. (200809120480584)

The website of Quality Control received complaints as early as in June, but the responses given from the site were mainly ‘Please provide detailed information’, ‘Report to the Ministry of Health’ and ‘Under investigation now.’

Sanlu group

As the culprit of the scandal, the Sanlu Group has also been taken as another important agent in these news texts. One important question is to what extent Sanlu Group is responsible for the incident. SZD presents the following official statements about the responsibilities of the Sanlu Group:

調查顯示A三鹿集團從今年A月份開始就陸續接到了一些患泌尿系統結石病的投訴A集團也開展了一些調查A包括患兒情況的調查A包括本集團產品質量的調查A包括原料奶站一些情況的調查A在確認奶粉的質量出現問題以後A三鹿集團也採取了召回部分市場產品A封存還沒有出庫的產品等措施A但是A三鹿集團在相當長的時間內沒有向政府報告A高強指出A在這個問題上A三鹿集團應該承擔很大責任. (200809140530004)

According to the investigation, Sanlu Group received repeated complaints in March about the calculus problem in urinary system. Sanlu Group **conducted some investigations**, including the conditions of the affected babies, the quality of its products as well as the conditions of the stations of its raw milk. After confirming that there were some quality problems with its products, Sanlu Group **also took some measures** like recalling its products in the market, sealed off those products which were still in store. However, Sanlu Group delayed for a long time in reporting this incident to the government. Gao Qiang pointed out that it was **on this issue** that Sanlu Group should take great responsibility.

These official statements suggest that Sanlu Group takes responsibility only for not reporting the incident to the government. Besides, it even represents Sanlu Group as an agent who has acted responsibly toward the consumers’ complaints. An evoked appraisal taken by SZD here is that Sanlu Group is only conditionally responsible for this incident.

However, GZD gives quite a negative evaluation of Sanlu Group. In the following example, it challenges Sanlu Group by criticizing the word *contamination* used by Sanlu Group to describe the incident:

透過那份召回聲明A我們需要注意三鹿集團的一個精心措辭——‘汙染’A顯然A從字面意思來看A三鹿集團以‘汙染’來暗示該事件是一場‘意外’A而有意地排除了可能的‘蓄意’行為A然而A召回聲明中所涉及的數據卻舉出了反證多達700噸奶粉受到‘汙染’A約175萬袋之巨A這豈是‘汙染’一詞所能含糊解釋得過去的?作為一家老牌奶粉生產企業A質量管理竟出現如此大的漏洞A讓700噸奶粉全都受到‘汙染’? (200809139213227)

Through the recalling notice, we should pay attention to the tactful wording by Sanlu Group – ‘contamination’. Apparently, Sanlu Group wants to use the literal meaning of this word to imply that the whole incident is an ‘accident’, excluding the possibility of an

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> 'intentional' act. However, the figure in the recalling notice demonstrates the opposite – as much as 700,000 kilograms is 'contaminated', which amounts to 1,750,000 bags. How can this be explained away with the simple word 'contamination'?Is it possible for an old brand industry of diary products to have such a great management problem to have 700,000 kilograms of milk products contaminated?

We can observe an inscribed appraisal with rhetorical devices such as statistics and rhetorical questions to question the responsibilities of Sanlu Group as well as the tactics utilized by the Sanlu Group to evade its responsibility.

SMD provides an even more negative evaluation of Sanlu Group by suggesting that it was not the first time Sanlu Group was involved in the scandal and questioning the root causes for the scandal, as seen in the following headlines of the two news reports in SMD:

> 三鹿奶粉曾涉'大頭嬰'事件. (200809120480585)
>
> Sanlu milk powder once got involved in the 'big-head baby' incident
>
> 三鹿公司何以漠視公衆生命安全. (200809130480045)
>
> How did Sanlu Group dare to be indifferent to the safety of the public?

The baby victims

The three newspapers also present different appraisal of the conditions of the suffering baby victims. SZD always seeks to present a positive evaluation of their conditions by downplaying the negative aspects of their conditions and highlighting their positive aspects. In the following example, negation is frequently used to mitigate the seriousness of the conditions of these baby victims:

> 6位患兒目前都在市兒童醫院留院觀察, 病情不重, 沒有出現腎衰等症狀, 腎功能都正常, 醫生採取保守治療, 估計留院觀察治療幾日後即可出院. (SZD, 16 September 2008, 綜合新聞)
>
> Six affected babies have been left for observation in the Shenzhen Children's Hospital. Their conditions are **not severe**, with **no** symptom of renal failure. Their kidney functions are **all normal**. The doctors are giving conservative treatment to them. They are expected to be able to leave the hospital a few days later.

Any situation can always be looked at from the positive side, no matter how severe it is. SZD always emphasizes the positive side no matter how awful the situations of these baby victims are. As a matter of fact, only those severely affected babies were allowed to stay in hospital, so the conditions of these babies were indeed very bad and emergent. However, SZD does not represent how serious their situations are and what kind of negative impact the milk incident may have on these babies.

Nonetheless, GZD presents a different picture. It gives a negative evaluation of the conditions of the baby victims, using such negative evaluative expressions as *very rare* and *very hard*. These are explicitly evaluative terms of Appreciation (e.g. *big*, *rare*) and Judgment (e.g. hard):

> 該院泌尿科的張醫生介紹, 小銘的結石不算大, 但在幼兒階段患結石很罕見, 鑒於年齡太小, 以及茶山醫院目前的水平難以治癒, 建議他到大型醫院進行專門治療. (GZD, 13 September 2008, A04)
>
> According to Doctor Zhang in the Urology Surgery of this hospital, Xiao Ming's kidney stone is **not that big**, but **very rare** for infants. In view of its young age and the medical

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conditions of Chashan hospital, it is **very hard** to cure it, so he recommended him to receive specialized treatment in large hospitals.

SMD provides an even more negative evaluation of the conditions of the baby victims, as seen in the following example:

'结石在婴儿阶段是非常罕见的，几年都不见一例。而且,这些婴儿来时都很凶险，基本上都下了病危通知.' 上海新华医院泌尿外科医生徐卯升说. (SMD, 12 September 2008, A09)

'Kidney stone is **very rare** for infants, **usually not seen for several years**. However, when these babies came, they were all **in very dangerous conditions**, **almost under critical condition**', said Xu Mao, a doctor in Urology Surgery in Shanghai Xinhua Hospital. (SMD, 12 September 2008, A09)

These different evaluations actually present different pictures of the conditions of these baby victims to the readers, indexing the different stances of each newspaper toward the problems experienced by the baby victims. And these different stances can be further illustrated in the following titles in which the speech by the same experts regarding the potential impact of the problems on the children is variably represented in the three newspapers.

規範治療不會造成永久傷害. (SZD, 14 September 2008)

With **appropriate** treatment, it will **not** cause permanent damages.

專家：及時規範治療不會有永久傷害. (GZD, 14 September 2008, A04)

Experts: With **immediate** and **appropriate** treatment, it will not cause permanent damages

專家解读是否會有永久傷害 專家稱應該不會, 但重症患兒應長期觀察. (SMD, 14 September 2008, A06)

When experts were asked whether there will be permanent damages, they said that it **may not**, but those babies in severe conditions should receive **long-term** observation.

When the speech of the same experts is recontextualized in the three newspapers, they are subject to different degrees of appropriation and manipulation in line with the dominant ideological stance of each newspaper. SZD recontextualizes the expert voice as its own voice and is highly committed to the evaluation that the problem will not cause permanent damage with appropriate treatment. However, in GZD, the speech or opinion from the expert is directly quoted, emphasizing the need for not only appropriate but also immediate treatment of the children, so as to prevent any permanent negative impact. As for SMD, it adds the less affirmative tone 'may not' and also cautions that 'those babies in severe conditions should receive long-term observation.' We can observe that while SZD, as a typical party press, is mainly concerned with the need to appease the worries of the public, especially the parents of those baby victims, GZD and SMD are committed to communicating the objective information to the public and caution them to take immediate and appropriate measures for the baby victims.

The worried parents

The worried parents constitute another group of agents in this incident, since it is these parents with babies who are very anxious about the truth of the incident as well as the impact of contaminated milk powder on their children. After the scandal was disclosed

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through the media, a large number of parents took their babies to the hospital for examination; and consequently, the hospitals were crowded with these anxious parents. This problem is represented in all the three newspapers but in very different ways.

SZD does not only give the smallest share of voices to these worried parents but also shows indifference to their worries. Sometimes it even implies those worried parents are troublemakers, as in the following:

> 在北京大學深圳醫院, 記者就見到一位家長清晨 6 點多就帶著 6 個月大的寶寶從龍崗中心城趕來就診, 為了等檢查, 一直排到了下午 2 點半, 在醫院耗了一整天。在各市屬醫院排隊的家長中, 就有不少是從寶安和龍崗兩區趕來的。還有的孩子雖然沒有食用'問題奶粉', 家長不放心也帶孩子來'湊熱鬧', 極大增加了醫院的壓力. (SZD, 19 September 2008, A06)
>
> In Shenzhen Hospital of Peking University, a parent from Longgang Central city was seen taking his six-month-old baby to see the doctor at about 6 o'clock in the morning. In order to wait for the examination, they queued until 2:30 p.m., **wasting a whole day there**. Among those parents queuing in each municipal hospital, quite a few of them came from Bao'an and Longgang district. There were also some children who did not feed on Sanlu milk powder, but the parents also took their babies to '**join in the fun**', **greatly increasing the traffic and pressure on the hospitals**. (SZD, 19 September 2008, A06)

The indifferent attitude held by SZD toward to the anxiety of these worried parents can be observed in its judgment evaluative expressions of the parents' behavior as 'join in the fun' and 'wasting a whole day' with an evoked evaluation of the parents as troublemakers by representing their action as 'greatly increasing the traffic and pressure on the hospitals.'

However, different from SZD, GZD has sympathized with the worries of these parents, using explicit evaluative expressions of Affect (e.g. most anxious and worried) in their reports:

> 三鹿腎結石患兒'事件發生後, 最緊張、最擔心的莫過於家長。近幾天, 凡是給孩子餵食過三鹿奶粉的家長紛紛帶孩子去醫院做檢查. (GZD, 17 September 2008, A09)
>
> After the breaking out of the incident of 'Sanlu-kidney-stone baby', **the parents are the most anxious and worried**. In recent days, those who have fed their babies with Sanlu milk powder all took their babies to the hospital for examination.

A similar attitudinal stance toward the parents can also be observed in the reports by SMD, with substantial uses of explicit evaluative expressions of affect in describing the parents:

> 得知三鹿奶粉有問題後, 我擔心得晚上都睡不著覺。現在醫生說寶寶沒事, 我才放心. (SMD, 17 September 2008, 佛山讀本蚤關注)
>
> Learning that Sanlu milk powder has quality problems, I was so **worried** that I **could not fall asleep** at night. It is not until the doctor says that my baby has no problem that I feel **relieved**.

> 昨日下午, 在市婦幼保健院兒科專門設立的'食用'三鹿奶粉', 嬰幼兒診室'里, 擠滿了焦慮的家長们. (SMD, 17 September 2008, 佛山讀本蚤關注)

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> Yesterday afternoon, the consultation room specially allocated to the babies fed on Sanlu milk powder in the City Maternal and Child Health Hospital was crowded with **worried** parents.

Summary of the findings

The main findings about the different attitudinal stance toward the four concerned parties in the incident are summarized in Table 4.

From Table 4, we can observe a continuum of positive versus negative evaluation among the three newspapers. SZD always holds positive stance toward the government's performance, is conditionally critical of the Sanlu Group, optimistic about the conditions of the suffering baby victims as well as the potential impact on them, and furthermore, indifferent to the worried parents. It represents a typical party organ, which always aims to construct a positive image of the government by positive appraisal of the government's performance, downplaying the negativity, or seriousness of the situation. It still features a typical propaganda style and an authoritative stance.

Nonetheless, for GZD, while it still holds a positive stance toward the government's performance, it is very critical of the Sanlu Group, holds negative evaluation of the Group's behavior, expresses deep sympathy with the worried parents and stays close watch about the situations of the suffering by the baby victims, with conditional optimistism about the potential impact of the incident. It is represented as serving two masters: both the government and the public. It aligns with both the government and the public and treats the Sanlu Group as the main target for criticism.

Among the three newspapers, SMD is characterized most by its negative stance toward the incident. Although it does not explicitly or severely criticize the government, it does implicitly suggest that the government should also be responsible for the scandal with its negligence of duty, questioning the root causes of the incident. It presents very negative evaluation of the Sanlu Group by indicating that it is not the first time the Group was involved in scandals. Meanwhile, it is sympathetic with the worried parents and presents a very serious picture of the suffering baby victims. From this perspective, it can be seen that SMD aligns mainly with the public and maintains an objective and credible image.

Table 4. Continuum of positive versus negative evaluation by each newspaper.

		SZD	GZD	SMD
The government		Very positive	Positive	Mildly negative
The Sanlu Group		Conditionally negative	Negative	Very negative
The baby victims	The figures	Always positive	Positive	Negative
	The conditions	Positive	Negative	Very negative
	The potential impact	Positive	Conditionally positive	Negative
The worried parents		Indifferent	Sympathetic	Very sympathetic

Note: SZD, Shenzhen Special Zone Daily; GZD, Guangzhou Daily; SMD, Southern Metropolis Daily.

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Discussion and conclusion

Adopting a dialectic approach which sees the universe as a unity of interdependent, interpenetrating, and interchanging parts (Shi-xu 2009a, 2009b), the present study attempts a move beyond the dichotomous perspective to examine the complexities and internal variations within contemporary Chinese media practice, with case studies of three key newspapers in southern China. Utilizing the holistic concept of stance by Du Bois (2007) and the relevant notions of evaluation from the Appraisal Theory by Martin and his colleagues, the study has examined how the three key newspapers in Southern China (i.e. SZD, GZD, and SMD) have evaluated, positioned, and aligned or disaligned with the agents and patients involved in the Sanlu milk scandal. Two competing forces in the changing Chinese media, i.e., the politically driven discourse and the professionally driven discourse, are found, and the differential extent of hybridization of these two discourses as practiced by the Chinese newspapers are uncovered.

Placing the three newspapers examined on a continuum between the politically driven discourse and the professionally driven discourse, we can observe that SZD represents the most politically driven, while SMD can be taken as the most professionally driven, and GZD being intermediate between the two. SZD positions itself as a typical party organ by aligning primarily with the government and giving a positive evaluation of the government's performance as well as downplaying their responsibilities for the scandal. It is indifferent to the public's interest and minimize the reports or voices of sufferings by the babies and parents. However, SMD represents a newspaper at another end of the Chinese media systems. It positions itself as a professionally driven newspaper by aligning primarily with the interests of the public with objective and balanced reporting. The sufferings and worries of the people related to the incident are highlighted and affectively evaluated. This does not mean that it is anti-government; but instead of doing propaganda for the government, it tries to investigate the root causes of the problem by releasing information which implies the government's negligence of the duty as well as the notorious record of the Sanlu group in the incident. GZD, however, tries to maintain a balance between its role as a party-organ and its role as socially responsible media for the public. Unlike SZD, it is not concerned with maintaining the image of the government only, but also concerned with the interests of the public. Nonetheless, unlike SMD, it does not align with the interests of the public so much as to question the truth – the problem of political, governmental corruption in China behind the incident. Thus, it represents a typical newspaper serving two masters: the party and the public.

The three newspapers examined in the present study are confined to the region of Guangdong, P. R. China; nonetheless, they represent varied ideology and positioning that are prevalent in the journalistic practice of the major newspapers of contemporary China. Apparently, the media discursive practice in contemporary China cannot be taken as under a monolithic system but is pushed and pulled to different directions by two competing forces – political controls and market forces, both within and outside of China (He 2000; Lee 2003). With profound marketization reform in Chinese media, we can observe more sophisticated state and relations of journalist practice today, i.e., more and more newspapers, even if they are the state-owned such as GZD, has to maneuver a bit away from the orthodoxical ideology of political or governmental authoritarianism and more toward greater public acceptance by way of enhanced professionalism. Consequently, we can observe that the two discourses, i.e., the politically driven discourse and the professionally driven discourse, are not only coexisting in the larger society and

respectively in different newspapers such as SZD and SMD, but they are also hybridized and coexisting within a single newspaper such as GZD.

As pointed out by Chen (2009) and Shi-xu (2009a, 2009b, 2010), simple contrasts or dichotomies drawn about the Western versus the Eastern/Chinese communication practice is no longer valid. In an increased glocalized[3] context, our intellectual inquiry must be built on the foundation of multicultural coexistence and toward a further understanding of the competing and hybrid discursive space in contemporary pluralistic communication practice.

Funding

This work was supported by RGC Directly Allocated Research Grant, Hong Kong [grant number #1 ZV7R].

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Notes

1. Martin (2000) and Martin and White (2005) have further classified the explicit evaluative expressions into three types: (1) affect (expression of feelings), e.g. happy, sad, and fear; (2) judgment (evaluation of behaviors), e.g. charmed, powerful, and moral; and (3) appreciation (evaluation of things), e.g. engaging, lovely, and innovative.
2. See Note 1 above.
3. Readers can refer to Wu (2008), for further readings of possible products and processes of glocalization in contemporary Chinese discourses.

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